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ACADEMIC VAULT

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Peer Pressure and Social Life: Keep Your Friends, Keep Your Standards

Make your own decisions about money, alcohol, relationships and belonging

CAMPUS LIFE

Campus Life

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

Freshers face new freedoms and new pressure at the same time. This pack explains how group influence works, gives scripts for refusing without drama, and helps you build friendships that support rather than undermine your goals.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Explain how conformity and social influence affect decisions.
- Recognise pressure around money, alcohol, cultism and relationships.
- Use clear, low-conflict refusal scripts.
- Build a social circle that supports your academic and personal goals.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Why pressure works

Humans are wired to avoid exclusion, and that wiring can override judgement.

- We look to others when unsure, especially in a new environment.
- We conform to avoid standing out or being rejected.
- Small requests escalate; agreeing once makes agreeing again easier.
- Groups create shared stories about what is normal.
- Being tired, lonely or financially stretched increases susceptibility.
- Naming the pressure reduces its power.

Know your lines

Decide your standards before the moment and rehearse simple refusals.

- Direct: 'No, I am not doing that.'
- Redirect: 'I am not drinking, but I will still come for the music.'
- Delay: 'I need to think about it; I will get back to you.'
- Exit: 'I have to go now.'
- Broken record: repeat the same short answer without justifying.
- Refuse cultism and criminal groups absolutely; there is no safe level of involvement.

> **Say no to money pressure**
> Never borrow to match someone else's spending. A friend who mocks your budget is describing their values, not your worth.

Build good friendships

The strongest protection against bad influence is a small group with shared standards.

- Choose friends you would be comfortable introducing to your parents.
- Look for consistency between what people say and do.
- Keep at least one friend who will tell you the truth.
- Invest in people who celebrate your progress rather than compete with it.
- Keep contact with family or a mentor outside campus.
- Ask for help early if you feel trapped or threatened.

Pressure is usually ordinary

Peer pressure is rarely a dramatic dare. It is the accumulated expectation of a group: what everyone wears, where everyone goes on Friday, what nobody admits to finding difficult. Most of it is harmless, and some of it is genuinely valuable - friends who insist you attend lectures are applying pressure in your interest.

The pressure that causes damage is usually about three things: money, substances and risk. Spending to keep up, drinking to belong, and joining activities whose consequences you have not considered. The pattern is always the same - a short-term social gain traded against a longer-term cost.

Notice which groups make you more yourself and which make you perform. That distinction is a better guide than any rule about who to avoid.

Refusing without a scene

Most people fear refusal because they expect it to be humiliating. In practice, a calm, brief refusal delivered without a lecture ends the matter almost every time. The mistake is over-explaining, which invites negotiation.